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Formosa

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MAR 4 1955

MEMORANDUM

To: The Secretary

Via: S/S

Subject: FORMOSA: The Origin of the Name

OIR IR-6858

In connection with your consideration of the desirability of changing the official name for Taiwan (Formosa), which is the subject of a separate memorandum, you may be interested in the following footnote to one of our intelligence reports:

> The name "Formosa," from the Portuguese "Isla Formosa" or "Beautiful Island" came into common usage during the period in the seventeenth century when Dutch rule over Formosa was first asserted. "Taiwan" (T'ai-wan) is the romanization of the Chinese name for the island, used also in Japanese. The characters t'ai wan mean "terraced bay," an apt description of parts of Formosa, and according to folk etymology this is the derivation of the Sino-Japanese name for the island. In fact, however, "Taiwan" appears to be a phonetic transcription of an originally non-Chinese name, now lost. The name "Formosa," which is almost never used in either Chinese or Japanese transcription, carries a greater implication of a non-Chinese, non-Japanese status than does the name "Taiwan," used officially by both China and Japan. Thus the use of the name "Formosa" by the Chinese Communists in their English-language propaganda at this time reveals the absence of an irredentist attitude toward Formosa. (However, technically speaking, neither name implies recognition of Chinese or Japanese status for Taiwan and both are equally correct usage.)

W. Park Armstrong, Jr.

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cc: G, C, S/P, FE, P, DRF, OLI:ge

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